



#### ◀ Mother of the kingdom

This is a Nigerian sculpture memorial of a queen mother. Such cast-brass heads were used to decorate altars dedicated to these influential women.

Women often created their own organizations that served them in public and private spheres.

In Owon, Nigeria, they formed *idegbe* groups (for married and unmarried daughters) and *ikposafen* (for wives of the family and married women) of a particular lineage.

Women of precolonial Africa also fought in armies. Among the Sotho of South Africa, daughters of subrulers often joined women's regiments, and the Amazons of Dahomey (see left) were famed warriors. Women led conquests and migrations to new territories for their people, too. For example, in the 16th century, Queen Amina of Zazzau (see pp. 36–37) conquered North African lands to bring the Hausa kingdom to the height of its power.

Since land was mainly community owned, no single individual had rights over it. In certain regions of Africa, such as Ghana, land came with clans, and marriage played an important role in keeping land within them. Because of this, families encouraged unions within the kinship group. Land was mainly cultivated by women; consequently, women were essential to land development. The Bambara women of West Africa, for example, controlled certain forest products and had customary rights to the land. Since most African states were agrarian and because women played such a large role in food production and processing, they were considered to be crucial players in the development of African economies.

#### ◀ Warriors of Dahomey

The Amazons were an all-female military regiment of the kingdom of Dahomey, now Benin, which lasted until the end of the 19th century. Pictured here in 1897, they were the only female combat troops at the time.